Ko'olau Summit Trail Traverse

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Abstract

The Ko'olau Summit Trail (KST) is 56 miles long with over 27,000 ft of elevation gain, and stretches from Pupukea to Makapu'u on the island of Oahu in Hawaii. The trail features challenging terrain, from mud and vegetation overgrowth to technical climbing. It has been successfully completed by less than 10 people. I finished the KST in 3 days, 9 hours, and 21 minutes both solo and unsupported.

1 Introduction

I grew up on Oahu hiking the occasional trail, but mostly traveled down the well beaten paths that were always crowded with tourists and never very exciting. I didn't really get into hiking until I accidentally stumbled upon a portion of the KST with a couple of my friends in 2020. We had heard that there was a trail that went from the Pali Lookout, past the Pali Puka and all the way up to Lanihuli, so we decided to give it a go. Minutes into the trail, we were all terrified. We were walking/crawling along the edge of the cliff with a deadly drop on either side. I had never felt such fear before in my life. One of my friends had enough and waited for us at the bottom of the trail, while my other friend and I successfully made it to the top. Hiking that trail was exhilarating and I was hooked immediately.

I later realized that I was hiking a small portion of the KST and that there was actually a trail that connected every summit in the Ko'olau Mountain Range. Typically people go on ridge hikes in the Ko'olaus and end their hikes at the summit. The KST doesn't actually start until you're at the summit, and then goes between the summits of all the other ridges. This means that you're getting the views of the summit nearly the whole time, but it also means you're walking/climbing/crawling on the edge of a cliff. I was fascinated by this seemingly unknown trail and had wondered if anyone had ever hiked the whole thing before. I could hardly believe that such a thing was even possible, but I looked it up and found that a few people had actually completed the whole thing. I began hiking different sections of the KST and one day decided that I wanted to do the whole thing in one-shot.

2 Preparation

I began planning this hike out in 2021. I had to figure out where my water sources were, what gear I needed, where I could camp, and how long it would take me to hike from each camp/watersite to the next. I knew that I had to become extremely comfortable on this trail, so I did my research and hiked every section of the KST individually. I finally finished hiking all the sections at the end of the summer in 2022 and I felt like I was ready to do the whole thing in one-shot. I was prepared to do it solo which is more difficult because you have less support on the trail and no one to talk to and try to solve problems with. I also wanted to do the hike fully unsupported, meaning that I carried all of my own food with me the whole time, slept up in the mountains, filtered water from streams, and didn't accept any food or water from people I met along the way. Why did I want to do all of this? I think I just wanted a challenge. This whole endeavor has been an incredible mental and physical challenge, with years of preparation going into it. Focusing on challenges is what gives me fulfillment in life, and this is the ultimate challenge.

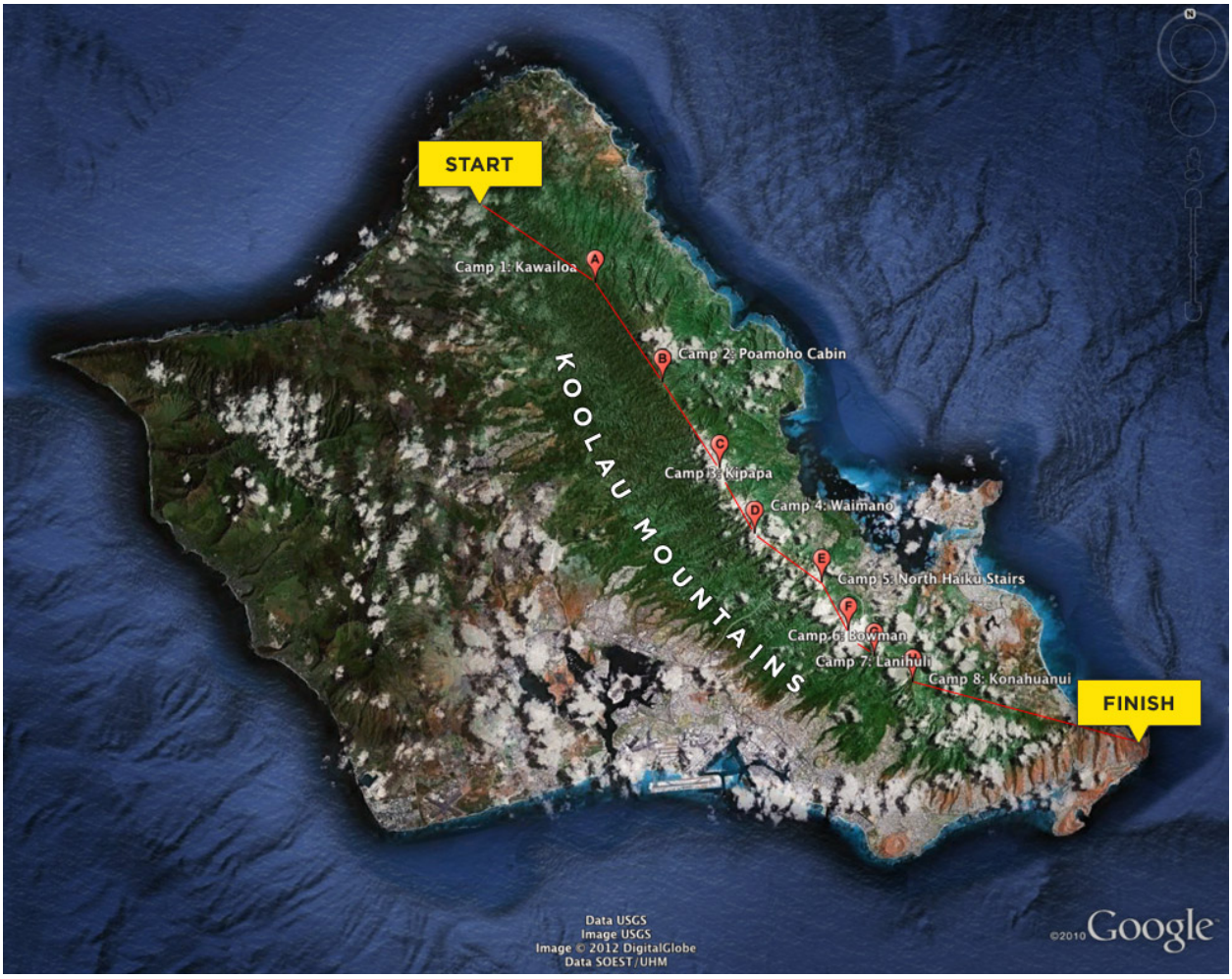


Figure 1: A map of the KST route created by Chase Norton, the trail's pioneer and the first person to successfully traverse its entire length. It took him 8 days, while my mission took less than half of that, meaning that I cut out a few of his camping spots.



Figure 2: Sho Heskett on one of our first hiking adventures on the KST

At the end of the summer in 2022, I attempted to hike the full KST and had to bail out on the second day because all of my electronics got soaked in a storm. I had done several overnight trips up on the KST before to prepare, but I had never had an issue with my headlamp, phone, or portable charger dying because I never had a heavy downpour. My backpack was rated to be water resistant so I thought that it would keep everything dry. Unfortunately, on this attempt, all of my electronics died and I did not want to continue along the trail because I felt that it would be too unsafe being unable to contact the outside world. I bailed out of Pauao ridge and I was disappointed by my failure. However, I learned that I just needed to waterproof my electronics better and I was motivated to try it again.

In September 2023, I finally felt ready to try a full KST attempt again. I was confident because at this point I had done most sections multiple times and was comfortable sleeping up in the mountains in difficult sleeping conditions without a tent.

3 Gear

Total pack weight with 3L of water: 23.2 pounds. Minimizing weight while on the KST is a key to success due to the fact that you are moving through an extremely overgrown trail with lots of elevation gain and technical climbing.

- Granite Gear Crown 3 60L Backpack: While researching this trail, I knew I was going to need a light backpack, so I looked up the best ultralight backpack and this came up as a good budget option. It is pretty light, but definitely too big for my purposes. I only utilized about half of the space within the pack. It would also have been nicer to have a smaller backpack that would allow me to duck and weave through the foliage with more ease. It is also advertised as being water resistant, but as I hiked the KST with it, it became quite obvious that it did not keep anything dry. By the end of my trip, every



Figure 3: The Chimney - One of the climbing features along the KST. Photo: Sho Heskett



Figure 4: Don't look down



Figure 5: Final preparations being made along the Kalihi Saddle. Photo: Sho Heskett



Figure 6: Just the bare essentials to allow me to survive

single piece of gear I owned was wet, including my electronics. On the bright side, I did like that it came with a chest pouch, which allowed me to reach items that I used frequently while hiking without having to take off my whole backpack.

- Columbia Men's Watertight II Rain Jacket: Cheap, lightweight jacket that I found online. Nothing fancy, but it kept me warm while it was raining.
- Long Sleeve T-Shirt: Hawaii Kai Boat Club rash guard. Perfect for keeping the sun off me while also keeping my arms from getting scratched up by branches along the trail. Long sleeves are absolutely necessary for this trail.
- Showa Atlas 300 Gloves Size L: Gloves are necessary for pulling yourself through the overgrowth of the trail. They kept my hands in good condition the whole time. I have tried out lots of different gloves and these are by far my favorite. They are cheap, light, and have fantastic grip.
- Patagonia Trail Pants: Lightweight, breathable, and stretchy. They were ripped apart by the end of the trail, but kept my legs from getting cut up by branches for the most part.
- Outdoor Research Ferrosi Thru Gaiters: I picked up these ankle gaiters just a few days before starting the hike in an attempt to keep debris out of shoes and keep my feet from developing blisters. They did

a great job at keeping debris out of my shoes and my blisters certainly would've been worse without them.

- 2 Pairs of Smartwool Hiking Socks: When I first started doing long hikes, I was using normal running socks and I was getting pretty bad blisters each time. I decided to invest in some hiking socks which improved my blisters a little bit. I also smother my feet in vaseline before I hike now to prevent blisters. With that all being said, I still ended up with some blisters nearly the size of golf balls on both my feet. Blisters seem to be an inevitable part of hiking the KST. Your feet are wet the whole time and you are walking on uneven ground, which is the perfect recipe for large blisters.
- Salomon Speedcross 5 Gore-Tex Shoes: These shoes have the perfect combination of grip and comfort. I tried both the Gore-Tex and the non-Gore-Tex version of these shoes and I can't really tell the difference. I thought that the Gore-Tex would keep water out of my shoes while allowing moisture to escape, but the inside of my shoes stayed wet for the entire duration of the hike.
- Outdoor Research Helium Bivy: I don't think I can in good conscience recommend anyone using this item to sleep on the KST. The absolute worst nights of sleep I've ever had have been inside this bivy. I decided to bring a bivy instead of a tent because it saves a lot of weight, but you sacrifice so much sleeping comfort because of it. It only keeps a marginal amount of moisture out if it rains and becomes a suffocation chamber as soon as you close it up. I can see it working well if you're camping in an area with low wind and no rain, but that really never happens on the KST.
- Eccopro Warm Weather Sleeping Bag: There are lighter sleeping bags out there, but this one was a great budget option for me. It didn't really keep me warm on this trip because it was wet the whole time, but when I've used it on past trips when it was dry, it worked well.
- Klymit Static V2 Sleeping Pad: Makes sleeping a lot more comfortable and is extremely light and compact. However, it does take considerable effort to blow it up and pack it up tightly.
- Toilet paper: Only brought enough to last for 2 days. Had to use leaves for rest of the time.
- 3L Camelbak Water Reservoir: Nice to be able to sip water without having to take your pack off, but difficult to monitor water consumption without being able to actually see the water level inside your bag.
- Two 1L Smart Water Bottles: Extremely light water bottles. Commonly used in ultralight backpacking. I used them when I needed to go far distances without being able to collect more water.
- Katadyn BeFree Water Filter 0.6L: Filters out harmful particles and leptospirosis, which is a common disease found in Hawaii's streams. Not fast at filtering water, but it definitely gets it clean. I haven't gotten sick from using it yet.
- Black Diamond Cosmo 300 Headlamp: Essential for setting camp up in the dark all three nights. The red light feature for preserving night vision is also nice to have. It doesn't attract as many bugs.
- Mregb Solar Powered Portable Charger: Provided more than enough power to charge my phone throughout the whole trip, but it was pretty heavy. Definitely could've gone with a lighter charger.
- iPhone SE/lightning charging cord: Essential for communicating my safety with the outside world as well as for logging my route and navigation. Should have gotten a waterproof case.
- CeraVe Hydrating Face Sunscreen: SPF 50, reef safe, mineral sunscreen
- Maui Jim Waterman Sunglasses: Protected my eyes and the built in strap kept them from falling off my face.
- Surf Ranch Hat: Kept my face from getting too sunburned.

- GoPro with Headstrap: Added a good amount of weight, but was worth bringing to document the trip.

4 Food

My goal was to eat 3,500 calories per day. My nutrition consisted of 26 Clif Bars, a whole Costco bag of Fancy Mixed Nuts, a bag of dried figs, 5 Lenny and Larry's protein cookies, and 8 Liquid IV Energy packets. I regret bringing so much food. It added a lot of weight to my pack and I didn't end up eating a lot of it. At the end of the hike I was left with 7 Clif Bars, and 2/3 of the bag of mixed nuts. It's difficult to eat so much food on a limited water supply. I lost about 15 pounds of body weight by the end of the trip, but I don't think I could've really eaten any more food due to my restricted water supply. However, the Liquid IV Energy packets really helped my energy levels. Whenever I felt a little sluggish, I would drink some Liquid IV infused water and immediately feel more rejuvenated.

5 Plan

I had planned my traverse to take about 3.5 days based off of how quickly I had hiked the sections previously. I didn't end up sticking to this plan because I was hiking faster than expected.

Day 1: Pupukea to Poamoho Cabin - 12 hours

- Once reach small hill next to fence, only a few more minutes to Koloa
- 7 hours to Koloa Cabin (eat lunch, filter water, use outhouse)
- Remember shortcut around water catchment
- 5 hours to Poamoho Cabin
- Turn right at Papali Junction
- Follow new fence, cross grassy area with debris to get to boot junction
- Snail jail close to Poamoho

Day 2: Poamoho to North Haiku - 14 hours

- Schofield about an hour and a half past Poamoho
- Water catchment system just after Schofield
- Go left at brown hiking sign junction towards Pauao
- Go left at next brown hiking sign junction
- Turn right to take upper trail at Kipapa with rusty pole
- Get water at the gap close to the corner
- Cross the fence at the gate after Eleao and descend down steep ridge, don't follow fence
- Waimalu Meadow also has water
- Fill up water at Halawa
- Lots of Guavas on Moanalua Saddle

Day 3: North Haiku to K1 - 12 hours

- Be careful going across the saddles
- Filter water at Pali Twin Falls 15 minutes to get down old Pali Road

Day 4: K1 to Makapuu - 13 hours

- Make sure you have plenty of water
- No water sources except for at Kaau Crater which is super out of the way
- Don't get lost around Hahaione
- 6 hours from Kuliouou to Makapuu, starts to get hot
- Tag lighthouse to finish

6 Mission

Day 1: Pupukea to Kipapa - 15 Hours The night before I began my hike, I tried to get to bed early, but the excitement of the next day woke me up 4 times throughout the night. I ended up waking up before my alarm at 3:45am and went through my checklist one last to make sure that I had everything I needed in my pack. I savored my last meal: a bowl of oatmeal, and drank 40 oz of water along with 2 Liquid IV packets. My dad then drove me up to the start of the trail at Pupukea on the North Shore. We arrived next to the Boy Scout Camp that I had spent many weeks at back when I was a Boy Scout, earning merit badges and learning outdoor skills. It was only fitting that the start of the trail was just next to the camp that I had spent so much of my time at. I thanked my dad for the ride and said my goodbyes, and then started walking down the paved road to the KST trailhead around 5:45am. It was still dark out and of course it started raining as soon as I started walking. The rain didn't bother me too much. The only thing I was concerned about was my electronics dying again like on my first attempt of the trail. This time, I had my electronics in a ziploc bag inside my chest pouch, so I was sure that they were better protected.

I made it to the trailhead at 6:26am after walking down the paved road for a few miles and began my journey into the most overgrown section of the KST. This is probably one of my least favorite parts of the trail because the trail is nearly nonexistent in a lot of parts and there are branches clawing at your entire body from head to toe with each step. Not to mention that it was raining and extremely muddy. Getting lost is always an issue on this section as well because there are several points where the trail splits and you have to choose the correct path. Unlike most of the trail where you are hiking along the cliff edge and you can see civilization below you, this part of the trail is socked deep within the mountains and you are isolated from the rest of the world. Despite the adverse weather conditions, I somehow made it to Koloa Cabin at 10:51am, over 3 hours earlier than I was expecting. I was planning on stopping at the cabin to refill my water via the water catchment system and have some lunch, but I was so inspired by the fact that I had gotten there so quickly that I decided to continue on to Poamoho Cabin without stopping.

I reached Poamoho Cabin by 3:30pm, and was absolutely astounded by the speed that I was hiking at. When I had hiked this part of the trail previously, it had taken me over 13 hours to reach this point, and here I was at my first day's planned destination after just 9 hours of hiking. I had planned on staying at the cabin for the night but I knew it was too early for me to set up camp, so I decided to keep hiking on. I knew that I could easily make it to Schofield before dark, so I filtered some water from the water catchment system at the cabin and moved onward. I left the cabin and was immediately greeted by the most incredible view of both Punalu'u and Kahana Valley. This short stretch where you are walking along a grassy path along the side of the cliff is one of my favorite parts of the entire trail and must be one of the most beautiful places in the world when the weather conditions are right. Of course, this beautiful section does not last long, and I re-entered the overgrown part of the trail after a few minutes. I reached the Schofield campsite after about an hour of hiking and once again changed my plan to try to make it all the way to Kipapa by the end of the day. This would be the furthest I've ever hiked on the KST in one day and would be combining 3 days worth of Chase Norton's original KST plan into one day. However, I felt confident that I could make



Figure 7: Being knee deep in mud is the norm on the northern section of the KST



Figure 8: One of the few signs marking the trail on the KST



Figure 9: The view just after leaving Poamoho Cabin

it and I was unafraid to hike at night if I needed to. I began pushing through the vegetation once again and around sunset, the Kipapa campsite was still nowhere in site. I checked my map to see how far I was from it, and I knew after looking that I was going to have to trudge on for a few hours in the dark. I took my second break of the day just as the sun was setting to eat a delicious dinner of Clif Bars and cookies, and brought out my headlamp. I hiked for what seemed like an eternity in the dark and finally reached Kipapa just after 9pm. I couldn't find the camping spot in the darkness and I was exhausted by this point, so I ended up just setting up my bivy/sleeping pad/sleeping bag in the middle of the trail and trying to get some rest. The rain and wind did not let up the entire night and my sleeping bag was fully soaked. I shivered throughout the whole night and wondered if I would succumb to hypothermia. Unfortunately I had nothing to warm me up so my best bet was to just stay inside my wet sleeping bag until the sun came out in the morning. Around 3:30am, I considered starting to hike the next section so that I could warm up my body, but as I tried to climb out of my sleeping bag to put my hiking gear on, my body was so cold that I couldn't put anything on. I gave up on that idea and just waited until sunrise. I ended up hiking for 15 hours on this day and did not see a single person the whole time.

Day 2: Kipapa to Stairway to Heaven - 13 Hours After getting about 3 hours of sleep the previous night, I was ready to begin the next day of hiking. Thanks to my ambitious night hiking adventure, I was now 5 hours ahead of schedule and figured that I would probably be able to make it to Stairway to Heaven by the end of the day if I pushed hard enough. I left Kipapa at 6:48am after packing up my campsite. I was now on the section of the KST that I had hiked only once before. This was also where the elevation change was about to increase a ton. I began the day trudging through the dewy foliage, socked in by gray clouds and 40 knot winds. I was finally hiking along the edge of the cliff so I can mostly see where I needed to be going. I made it to the corner and decided to filter some water from the stream there, but only just enough so that I could consume my daily dose of 2 Liquid IV packets. I didn't want to fill up too much water and weigh my pack down, especially since there are many water sources along this part of the trail.

After what seemed like an eternity of ups and downs, I passed Waimano and made it to Waimalu Meadows. This is another one of my favorite parts of the trail. It is an idyllic meadow with a beautiful



Figure 10: Stopping for water at the corner

stream running through it and no one else around. One day, I'll spend the day up there to fully appreciate its beauty, but I was on a mission and just stopped briefly to filter some water before continuing on.

Towards the end of the afternoon, I finally pushed past Aiea and made it to Stairway to Hell. I looked across the Moanalua Saddle and saw Stairway to Heaven way over on the other side and questioned if I had enough time in the day to make it across the saddle to my intended destination. I made some quick calculations and decided that I could probably make it past the difficult climbing sections on the saddle before dark. The Moanalua Saddle is the northernmost of the three main saddles along the KST. The saddles are known for their extreme elevation change, deadly cliff drops, crumbly rock, and difficult climbing. The saddles are the most technically challenging part of the trail and I was about to attempt to rush through one, partially in the dark. I would definitely not recommend doing this. I hiked as fast as I could and climbed up all the difficult sections just before it became completely dark. I had to hike the last 30 minutes in the dark up to Stairway to Heaven, but the last part was not as dangerous or difficult so I was fine. At long last, I had made it to the old US Naval Radio Station building at the top and set up camp inside, safe from the wind and rain. I was so relieved that my risk had paid off and I had made it successfully across one of the three saddles. I also had the best night of sleep, clocking in about 10 hours since I was out of the wind and rain. My sleeping bag was wet, but I was so exhausted by this point that I could fall asleep despite being uncomfortably cold.



Figure 11: Cloudy but still beautiful views all around



Figure 12: Waimalu Meadows, nestled in one of the most remote parts of the island



Figure 13: Stairway to Hell, although overshadowed by the grandeur of the Stairway to Heaven just to the south, is characterized by its weathered, rusty steps



Figure 14: Kalihi Saddle: *gulp*

Day 3: Stairway to Heaven to Ka'au Crater - 13 Hours I woke up simultaneously to my alarm and to voices outside of the building at 5:30am. A couple people came inside and were surprised to see me sleeping in there. I welcomed them inside and ended up having a great conversation with them about the journey that I was on. They were supportive of me and offered food and water, but I had to decline since I was trying to complete the trail unsupported. My talk with them really lifted my spirits and set me in a great mood to start the most dangerous section of the KST. It was a cloudy morning, but just as I reached the start of the Kalihi Saddle, the clouds lifted, revealing the beauty and danger of the most difficult and spine-chilling section of the KST. I peered down the saddle to see deadly drops on either side of me with large teeth looking rocks lining the saddle that I knew I would have to climb up and down. I knew that if I was going to get hurt on any part of the trail, this would be it. It is so incredibly sketchy that even the best hikers worry about getting across safely. One wrong move can lead to slipping down the cliff to death. I told myself to take it slow and to maintain focus the whole time. I was already ahead of schedule, so I had plenty of time to make sure that I made it across safely. I moved through each climbing problem slowly and carefully and made it through to the other side with no hiccups. It was an incredible relief making it across, because I knew I had done the most difficult part of the trail and was now getting into more familiar territory that I had hiked many times before. I sped down from Lanihuli to the Pali Lookout, making sure to be careful around the "W" and the "anvil drop", and finally made it to one of the only places where the KST crosses over with the rest of civilization.

I saw a whole bunch of tourists enjoying the view, probably staring at me because I looked like a crazy disheveled person who just emerged from the forest. I went around the gate and down the Old Pali Road about 15 minutes to reach a small stream where I filled up my water once again. I knew that this was going to be my last water source before the finish so I filled up my entire 5L capacity. This made my pack pretty heavy, but it was necessary for me to have enough water for the rest of this day and the next one. I walked back up the Old Pali Road and found my parents at the lookout, who had come to check in on me and offer food and water. Of course, I declined their offer, but I was glad to see them and happy to almost be at the end of the trail. I was very familiar with the rest of the trail and I believed that the hardest part was over.



Figure 15: A brief visit with civilization at the Pali Lookout

Oh boy was I wrong.

I left my parents and began the terrifyingly steep trek up to K1. My pack was so heavy and the sun had just come out of the clouds and was making me sweat bullets. I moved very slowly, stopping every 15 steps to catch my breath. I slowly worked my way over the notches and up the chimney with no problem, but I was getting tired from carrying so much weight with all the elevation gain. By the time I reached the top of K1 over 2 hours later, I had consumed about half of my 5L water supply that was supposed to last me into the next day. I knew I was probably going to run out of water near the end of the trail at this point because I had consumed so much water already. I began rationing water and made my way over to K2 in the mid-afternoon. I checked my phone there and suddenly realized that my phone had stopped recording my GPS tracks since I made it across the Kalihi Saddle. This was disappointing to me because my tracks were how I would prove that I actually hiked the whole thing. At least I had GoPro videos of myself while I was hiking during this missing section. I resumed my recording on my phone and continued on, determined to make it to Mount Olympus by the end of the day. At this point, the fatigue was starting to set in. I was getting tired due to hiking for such a long period of time over rough terrain and with dubious sleep. I could feel my feet also starting to develop blisters. My feet had been wet since the very beginning of the hike and looked wrinkled and beaten to a pulp. Fortunately, I looked over Manoa valley and to the city and saw the most magical sunset. It made me relax and realize that I had already gone so far. I was back in town and I was almost to the finish. I reached Mount Olympus just before dark, but decided to push just a bit further to take advantage of the cooler weather.

I knew that the next day would be scorching hot with no wind on the hottest part of the trail. I made it to the top of Ka'au Crater at 7:15pm and setup camp. I heard a buzzing around me and thought that it was probably just the power lines just South of me, but after I got stung by 4 bees, I think it was actually a beehive that I had setup right next to. I turned off my headlamp so as not disturb the bees anymore and fell asleep promptly. Luckily, there was no wind and rain that night, so I had another decent night of sleep before my final day of hiking.



Figure 16: An incredible sunset marking the end of a full day of climbing and steep drops



Figure 17: Final day. The water below me was looking really inviting at this point. Not much cloud cover, no wind and the sun on full blast

Day 4: Ka'au Crater to Makapu'u Lighthouse - 9 Hours The home stretch. I knew that this was going to be the shortest day of hiking, but I was worried a lot by my diminishing water supply. I started hiking before the sun came up and tried to travel as fast as I could while the sun was not blazing yet. I knew that once the sun came up, I would have to slow down and start drinking a lot more water. Moisture had gotten to my phone charger and killed it, so I knew that my phone would die before I reached the finish line. I reached Kuli'ou'ou at 9:45am and knew that I had about 6 more hours ahead of me in the hot sun. I drank the last of my Liquid IV and moved on towards Hahaione. I've done this section countless times and I still manage to miss the turn and get lost every time. This time was no different. I proceeded to head down the wrong trail, but fortunately I noticed after 5 minutes and backtracked to the right trail. This was a minor inconvenience that I was anticipating. I then made my way over to Mariner's ridge and across to Kamilo'iki ridge. Looking out over Waimanalo Bay was absolutely stunning, and I could see beautiful waves breaking in Maunalua Bay. I really wished I was in the ocean at this point instead of burning up in the mountains. Just before I got to Kamilo'iki ridge, I crossed paths with 2 guys who said they had started hiking from Makapu'u and were heading North on the KST for a day hike. I told them about where I had just come from and they said they were also interested in hiking the whole KST. They were super friendly and supportive of me making it to the end. I was really struggling at this point and they were crucial in giving me the energy to make it to Makapu'u.

I continued on to Dead Man's Catwalk and at this point the dehydration really started hitting hard. This was also around the point where my phone died and my GPS tracks stopped. I ran out of water and tried eating a Clif Bar, but it tasted like cardboard when I bit into it and I could not get it to go down my throat because it was so dry. I had to spit it out and keep going, hoping that I could make it to the end before I passed out from dehydration. Each step was agonizingly slow and I tried to not push myself too hard because I did not want to faint at the finish line. I took off my shirt to try and cool my body down and then continued down to the Makapu'u Lookout. I was so close to finishing but I was also struggling so much. Every step was painful. I have never had to work as hard as I did to make it up that final section to



Figure 18: A big hug for the Makapu'u lighthouse. So much relief making it to the finish line.

the lighthouse. Luckily, my friend Gavin found me at the lookout and joined me on the final stretch to the lighthouse. I was relieved he was there to take care of me in case I passed out. Amazingly, I made it to the top of the final hill and walked over to the lighthouse where my parents and friends were waiting for me. I swung around the fence and gave the lighthouse a big hug to signify that I had officially completed the KST. A huge wave of relief washed over me and I was so happy that my friends and family had brought lots of food and drinks for me. That evening, I consumed more calories than I ever had before in such a short period of time. My stomach felt like a bottomless pit and I gulped up 5 full meals like nothing. I weighed myself and I had lost over 12 pounds over the past three and a half days. This was an incredible experience that I am so glad that I completed. If I had failed again, the trail would keep haunting me and I would have to keep trying each year until I finally finished it.

7 Takeaways

I've learned many lessons from hiking this trail. Hiking the KST over the course of just a few days felt like flipping a switch on my life from easy to nightmare mode instantly. Now that I'm back in my daily routine, I've come to appreciate how good living with modern comforts really is. Being able to have instant access to clean water and food, not worrying about trying to survive at every waking moment is an incredible gift that I've always taken for granted. I can't imagine complaining about things anymore. Whenever something doesn't go my way, I just think back to when I was shivering cold, alone up in the mountains and think about how good I have it now.

It took levels of determination and grit inside of me to finish this trail that I wasn't sure if I had in me before, and I hope that it will transfer over to other aspects of my life. I feel like I know my body and mind's limits better than ever now and will continue to push my boundaries to improve my life and the lives of those around me.

The Boy Scout motto is "Be Prepared", and I've never resonated with that more in my life. It took incredible preparation for me to pull this off and I now have more confidence than ever to accomplish bigger tasks as long as I am calculated in my preparation.

Lastly, I have an increased sense of appreciation for the power of nature. Throughout the whole hike, I felt like nature was clawing at me, trying to get me slow down and drop dead, and it was an incredibly strong force to fight against. I feel like I sometimes forget that I'm just one person and that nature has much more power than I do.

8 Acknowledgements

I'd like to thank my dad for dropping me off at the trailhead at Pupukea and picking me up from Makapu'u and to both of my parents for always believing in me and providing support on the sidelines. I can't thank them enough for allowing me to embark on this once in a lifetime opportunity. I'd also like to thank my friends Gavin Ball, Luke Kaminskas, and Brennan Kimura for meeting me at the finish line along with my parents. I am extremely appreciative for their support and the much needed food and water after I was through with the hike. I met many people along the way, and although I had to respectfully decline their food and water, I appreciated their company on an otherwise lonely journey and talking with supportive strangers along the way was a huge motivation in getting me to the end. A big thank you to Sho Heskett for getting me inspired to go hiking in the first place and to everyone else who helped me train for this hike both in Hawaii and California: Reed Gallagher, Logan Ghafouri, Lucas Sutorus, Aidan Cruise, and more.

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9 Disclaimer

I strongly advise against attempting to hike this trail. There are compelling reasons why exceedingly few individuals have successfully traversed it. The majority of its segments are not only legally restricted but also pose severe safety hazards. This is not a trail that you can just come to Hawaii on vacation to hike. You must know the trail very well. However, if you are still determined to hike it, do each section separately and become extremely comfortable with each part before ever attempting to do it all in one-shot. It took me many nights up in the Ko'olau Mountains before I ever felt comfortable enough with the trail to do a full one-shot attempt.